

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Substitute Pitcher

Grade 5 reading comprehension · Story · 14 points · About 25 minutes

The bleachers at Maple Park were packed for the championship game, and the noise rolled over the field like thunder. Dani Reyes stood at the edge of the dugout, gripping her glove so tightly that her knuckles turned white.

A few minutes earlier, the Hawks' starting pitcher, Marcus, had twisted his wrist while diving for a ball. Coach Williams had scanned the bench, and his eyes had stopped on Dani. "You've been practicing that fastball all season," he said. "Today you get to use it."

Dani had pitched in practice a hundred times, but never in a real game, and never with so many people watching.

Now it was the bottom of the sixth inning. The Hawks were ahead 4–3, but the other team had loaded the bases, and there were two outs. Dani walked to the mound on legs that felt like jelly. The batter, a tall boy with a scowl, tapped the plate with his bat. Dani's heart hammered so loudly that she was sure the whole park could hear it.

She glanced at the dugout. Behind her, the shortstop, Priya, pounded her glove and called, "You've got this!" Coach Williams cupped his hands around his mouth. "Just play catch!" he shouted. "Like in your backyard!"

Dani closed her eyes and pictured her grandfather, standing in the backyard with his old leather mitt, saying, "Easy does it, mija. Nice and smooth." Her shoulders loosened. She opened her eyes, stared at the catcher's glove, and let the ball fly.

Strike one. Strike two. The tall boy swung hard at the third pitch and hit nothing but air. The umpire threw up his fist, and the crowd erupted. Dani's teammates poured out of the dugout. Marcus, his wrist wrapped in an ice pack, was the first to reach her. "Great job, Dani!" he said, grinning. "You saved us."

1. Why did the Hawks need a new pitcher? (1 point)

2. Copy the exact words from the first paragraph that show how tightly Dani was holding her glove. Use quotation marks. (2 points)

3. The story says the batter had a “scowl.” What does this tell you about him? (1 point)

4. The story says Dani’s legs “felt like jelly.” What does this comparison show about how she felt? (2 points)

5. Quote two different phrases from the story that show Dani was nervous on the mound. Use quotation marks around each one. (2 points)

6. Why do you think Dani closed her eyes and pictured her grandfather? Quote part of the text to support your answer. (2 points)

7. How did Coach Williams help Dani on the mound? Quote his words in your answer. (2 points)

8. Write a summary of the story in two sentences. Tell what the problem was and how it was solved. (2 points)

Writing task: Write the next scene. The Hawks celebrate. What does Dani say to Marcus and her grandfather?
